35. Pinocchio

Long, long ago, there lived.....

'A king !' you will say immediately. No children. You are mistaken. Once upon a time, there was a piece of wood. A common block of firewood. It was found in the shop of a carpenter. But whenever he put his tools to the block to cut it, to carve it, or to scrape it, it began to talk - 'Oh, that hurt !' 'Don't break me, please.' 'Oh, that tickles !'

Just then, his neighbour Geppetto came in to ask for a piece of wood. Geppetto wanted to make a wooden puppet that could run, jump and make its way around in the world. So the carpenter readily gave the piece of wood to Geppetto.

Geppetto brought the piece home and carved it into a puppet, lovingly. As he had no family, he began to think of the puppet as his son, and named him Pinocchio. But Pinocchio was quite a naughty puppet. As soon as Geppetto taught it to walk, he ran out of the hut. He ran so fast that Geppetto could not catch him. A policeman caught him and brought him back to Geppetto.

Though Pinocchio was such a naughty puppet, Geppetto loved him dearly. He would do anything for his son. But Pinocchio was not always nice to his father. He always promised to be a good boy and tell the truth and obey his father, but more often than not, he forgot all his promises.

Pinocchio wanted to be a real boy, a real son to his father and not just a wooden puppet. He meant well, but he was only a little wooden puppet and did silly things he should not have done. You can read about all his antics in a book called 'The Adventures of Pinocchio', but here are some of them in short.

Pinocchio thought he would go to school, learn reading in a day, writing the next day and then arithmetic on the day after that. Then he planned to earn a lot of money for Geppetto. Geppetto felt very happy that Pinocchio wanted to go to school. But he did not have the money for the schoolbook. Though it was very cold, poor Geppetto sold his only coat to get the money for Pinocchio's schoolbook.

Pinocchio started for school. On the way, he came upon a puppet show. He forgot all about his plans to go to school. The naughty puppet that he was, he sold his schoolbook and with that money, bought a ticket to the show.

When Pinocchio entered the puppet theatre, the puppets on the stage saw him. They were very happy to see their brother. They forgot their play and began to call out to him. In two leaps, Pinocchio was on the stage. They all began to hug and slap one another on the back, and jump and clap. People who had come to see the play did not like this interruption at all. They began to shout.

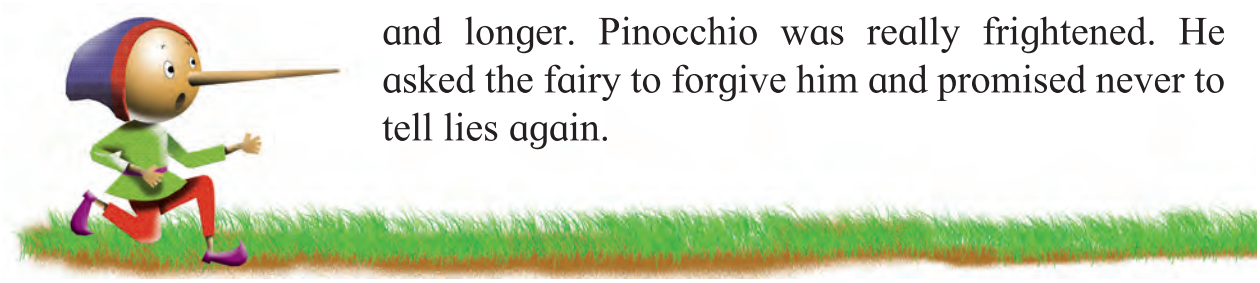
The puppet master was very annoyed. He decided to throw Pinocchio into the fire. Pinocchio's puppet friends pleaded with the puppet master not to do that. Then, instead of Pinocchio, the puppet master chose another puppet for throwing into the fire.

Now, Pinocchio was really good at heart. He was sorry for the other puppet. Very gallantly, he told the puppet master that he was ready to burn in the fire himself and the puppet master should spare the other puppet's life.

The puppet master was not really a wicked master. He let both the puppets go. Not only that, he also gave Pinocchio five gold coins for his old father Geppetto, when he heard his story.

Now, did Pinocchio take these coins to Geppetto immediately ? No, the silly little puppet that he was, he got into more and more mischief and trouble due to the coins.

A kind fairy saved Pinocchio from the robbers who had caught Pinocchio for the coins. But when the fairy asked Pinocchio about the coins, he lied to her. But then, a strange thing happened. The moment Pinocchio told a lie, his nose grew longer. With every lie, it grew longer and longer. Pinocchio was really frightened. He asked the fairy to forgive him and promised never to tell lies again.



Pinocchio did not learn to tell the truth or listen to the good advice of his friends and his father and the fairy easily. So, at the end of a number of adventures, do you know where he found himself ? At the bottom of the sea !

And there, he was swallowed by a big shark that was one mile long. Poor Pinocchio ! Now at last, he was truly sorry for all the foolish things that he had done. But once you get into a difficulty, its not very easy to get out of it.

However, inside the stomach of the shark, Pinocchio saw a faint light. When he went near the light, surprise of surprises ! He found Geppetto !

Geppetto had been worried about Pinocchio since he had left home. He had searched for Pinocchio far and wide. During

the search, the shark had swallowed the ship on which Geppetto was travelling ! With great effort and courage, Pinocchio took himself and Geppetto out of the sharks's stomach. He carried Geppetto back to the shore.

After that, Pinocchio really proved to be a good boy. He began to work very hard to help Geppetto. When he heard that the fairy was ill, he sent her all the money that he was saving for himself. And then to his joy and amazement, he found that he had turned into a real boy !

– *Based on 'The Adventures of Pinocchio' by Carlo Collodi.*

Things to do :

1. Answer the following questions :
   (a) Why did the carpenter give the piece of wood to Gepetto ?
   (b) What did the Puppet Pinocchio want ?
   (c) Why could Pinocchio not become a real boy ?
   (d) Why did Pinocchio's nose become long ?
   (e) How did Pinocchio become a real boy at the end ?
2. Give one example each of the following :
   (a) Pinocchio's naughtiness
   (b) Pinocchio's silly ideas about school
   (c) Geppetto's love for Pinocchio
   (d) The puppet master's kindness
3. Use the following words in your own sentences or short paragraphs :
   * readily * lovingly * annoyed * pleaded
   * gallantly * immediately * at last * truly
4. Write / Tell any one of Pinocchio's adventures in short, in your own words.
5. Write / Tell about any one silly thing that you have done.
6. Write / Tell about any occasion when you wanted to help others.
7. Complete the following sentences in as many ways as possible :
   * Once upon a time, ...
   * Early one morning, ...
   * Last night, ...